

for you, without comparing other's actions.

If your money situation has gotten out of control and talking about it amongst yourselves hasn't happened or hasn't worked, you should consider professional counseling before you do something as drastic as get a divorce. If the relationship does end up in divorce, certain precautions should occur prior to separating.

Since joint debts are both parties' responsibility, it is a good idea to close all joint accounts so that no further debt can be added. Creditors can and will come after any party that they think has the capacity to pay. They will usually go after the person who has the money, regardless of whom the court has assigned the responsibility to pay the debt.

Opal and Paul had tried to work it out. They were in their mid-twenties and had been married for five years. They had been going to a marriage counselor for the past two years, but they could never seem to resolve their problems. Finally, they were full of so much anger that they couldn't stay married any longer. This anger was apparent during their divorce proceedings. They only communicated to each other through their lawyers.

It was an ugly settlement. They fought to the bitter end over the division of their property. They each ended up with roughly half of the assets and half of the debts since they had comparable incomes and no children. All of their credit cards were joint accounts so the judge divided them up and assigned each person half of the debts to repay. From that moment on, Opal no longer felt any sense of responsibility for the debts assigned to Paul. This turned out to be a false sense of security.

Opal went about her new life without Paul and consistently paid her half of the joint debts that had been assigned to her. One year after their divorce, she received a phone call from a creditor saying she owed on a credit card that had been

